

Frame Hypothesis

If the problem is silence after input, build a visible answer — not a bigger microphone.

WHICH PARADOX

Input without answer. A public board needs open participation to be legitimate, but unstructured participation with no public reply can erode the legitimacy it is meant to create. This is the pod’s Effort vs. Impact paradox at the scale of one local meeting: when people cannot see whether their effort counted, opting out is rational — and each quiet exit makes the next person’s effort even less likely to matter.

Value	Public comment exists to make local decisions legitimate. A board invites people to speak so the process is open and residents have a real chance to be heard.
Failure	That same invitation — unstructured testimony with no visible reply — produces the opposite of legitimacy. The more people speak into silence, the more clearly the institution shows that participation may not matter.
Trap	The obvious fix is more outreach: more meetings, easier forms, bigger turnout. That pours more voices into the same silent system. Decide faster with fewer speakers and you restore action, but you destroy the openness that made the meeting democratic.

THE REFRAME

*Everyone assumes this is a problem about getting more people to participate. **What if it’s actually a problem about whether an institution can make listening visible?***

This shift moves the failure point from resident motivation to institutional response design. What becomes visible is who owns the reply, when it is due, what was heard in aggregate, and whether the answer was yes, no, or not yet. What stops mattering is raw comment volume, longer meetings, and “more civic engagement” as a goal in itself. A smaller closed loop on one agenda item is a better hackathon test than a bigger open mic.

THE STAKEHOLDER

Chair of a D.C. Advisory Neighborhood Commission (ANC). Every commissioner has a public email, and the chair already runs the meeting where neighbors speak. They want people to keep coming and to feel the commission is worth a Tuesday night. They are frustrated that after they take testimony, the only public artifact is minutes almost nobody reads — so the same neighbors either stop showing up or repeat the same comment next month. This frame lands because it does not ask them for a citywide platform or new statute. It asks them to adopt one item, name who owns the reply before comment opens, post a short “what we heard,” and send a dated yes / no / not yet. That is work they can try at the next regularly scheduled meeting.

THE TESTABILITY CHECK

LANDING-PAGE HEADLINE
<i>You spoke. Here’s what the board heard — and what it decided.</i>